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Student Right - Educational Testing Service
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Educational Testing Service (ETS) is a nonprofit company that provides assessment services for schools, colleges, and universities. ETS developed a Web-based TOEFL (Test of English as a Foreign Language) application to measure the English proficiency of non-English speakers. In the past, students who wanted to take the TOEFL had to register for the test at a test center and use a pencil to fill in the answer key and the written test on paper. Since its online introduction, ETS has also added many Certified Test Administration Sites (CTAS) for TOEFL. Furthermore, each testing facility provides test takers with a personal computer (PC) and Internet access. Consequently, these testing facilities have been receiving many complaints from students and counselors about insufficient seating and PCs, as well as technical difficulties with the new technology. In many of these cases, this has resulted in last-minute cancellations of scheduled tests.

ETS is one of many software providers of online testing applications. Technology requirements are the software packages, operating systems, databases, and physical hardware devices—wires, routers, bridges, and fiber and Ethernet. These technology requirements and ETS online testing solutions are the main components for delivering TOEFL. For CTAS to offer these test services, all technology services must run reliably and smoothly. In addition, these testing facilities need to provide up-to-date PC workstations, high-speed Internet access, and technical staff. Most importantly, a secure data infrastructure is essential to store students' test results and other personal information.

Web-based TOEFL cannot exist without the physical network infrastructure and is one component of the technology infrastructure. The physical infrastructure includes the Web server,

the database server, computers, hardware devices, operating systems, and ETS' testing software. Web-based TOEFL software needs to be installed. In addition, Internet access to the world outside CTAS, as well as among other testing facilities, including networks and the Internet.

One of the key services for CTAS is the technical support staff. In fact, they are considered even more important than the testing facility itself. It is the technical staff who not only keep the testing facilities running and up to date but also assist students who must take the Web-based TOEFL. CTAS is only possible if the technical support staff makes it available and enables TOEFL to be scheduled and administered.

A successful CTAS delivery will serve as a model for other educational services delivered through technology. To offer online tests, ETS needs to provide assessment software, up-to-date PC workstations, high-speed Internet access, and staff training. Most importantly, a secure data infrastructure is needed to run the application and store data.

In conclusion, both ETS and CTAS are important, but technology infrastructure is one of the most important pieces. After all, technology makes it all possible. In addition to ETS and CTAS, technology is a key component to deliver the online TOEFL. Are these investments worth it? I think so. As Gates has pointed out, we always overestimate the change that will occur in the two years and underestimate the change that will occur in the next ten (pg. 69). For this reason, I believe that technology is not only important to educational testing services but also to the future of teaching and learning.

References

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- Michael Alison Chandler (2006). *After Going Online, TOEFL Is Experiencing Growing Pains*. Retrieved September 18, 2006, from <http://www.washingtonpost.com/wp-dyn/content/article/2006/09/17/AR2006091700626.html>.